

The Power LEDGER

In the past few decades, women have quietly risen across India's banking, financial services, and insurance sector. Here women's leadership isn't the exception, it's the legacy **BY ANAND ADHIKARI**

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HEN ARUNDHATI BHATTACHARYA was transferred to Lucknow in the mid-2000s to become the new General Manager, she considered bidding goodbye to State Bank of India (SBI), the country's largest bank. Her biggest worry was finding a good school for her daughter. The decision to move from her hometown, Kolkata, was difficult.

Her mentor M. S. Verma's advice came in handy. The former chairman of SBI and TRAI encouraged her to take the opportunity saying she had come a long way and there was no question of giving up when she was so close to reaching the top. Bhattacharya took that advice—and it turned out to

be the best decision she made, as years later she would shatter one of India's oldest glass ceilings by becoming the first woman to head the country's largest bank.

Vibha Padalkar, the MD & CEO of HDFC Life, didn't have to look far for inspiration or advice like Bhattacharya, since most of it came from her family. "I come from a family that has had several accomplished women, including my mother, who was a trailblazer herself," she says. Her mother was a 1964-batch IAS officer. Her aunts were accomplished in their respective fields, too, ranging from doctors to filmmakers. "The 'finance spark' was ignited by my uncle, who was a finance director him-